

County Administration Workshop: July 14, 2026

1:30 p.m. – Board of Commissioners Conference Room

Attending: Commissioners Ron A. Smith; Colene M. Martin; Gary L. Richardson; and Nikole Guzman, Recorder

Chair Ron Smith called the meeting to order at 1:32 p.m.

1. Declaration of Potential Conflicts of Interest

The board declared there are no potential conflicts of interest.

2. Department Business

a. Legal Counsel

1. 4H Extension – OSU Service District IGA

Wally Hicks, County Counsel, presented the proposed Intergovernmental Agreement between the Josephine County 4-H/Extension Service District and Oregon State University Extension Service. Jamie Davis, OSU Southern Oregon Regional Director, joined the meeting remotely to answer questions regarding the agreement, facilities, expenditures, travel reimbursements, and longer-term operational plans.

Ms. Davis explained that the Fiscal Year 2026-2027 budget includes approximately \$1,650 per month to lease office space at Rogue Community College. The lease includes the office area and certain services, including janitorial service and refuse collection. The space will be vacant when occupied and must be furnished. Approximately \$40,000 to \$44,000 was included in the adopted budget from the District's building reserve fund for cubicles, desks, chairs, and related durable furnishings. Ms. Davis clarified that OSU intends to purchase, rather than lease, the furnishings and that the equipment could be relocated and reused if Extension later moves into a larger or more permanent facility.

The Board discussed whether the proposed RCC space would adequately satisfy OSU's obligations under the agreement. Ms. Davis stated that it would meet the District's immediate staffing and operational needs. She anticipated the location could remain suitable for one or two years but acknowledged that Extension may eventually require additional classroom and educational space. Future options could include leasing a larger area at RCC or identifying another long-term location. The Intergovernmental Agreement does not expressly govern the District's separate building reserve fund, which was created by the Board for the purchase, improvement, or equipping of Extension facilities.

Commissioners also requested clarification regarding travel expenses for OSU faculty based outside Josephine County. Ms. Davis explained that faculty located in Central Point are reimbursed by the Service District only for travel to and within Josephine County while providing services to County residents. Josephine County funds are not used for the employees' office space, computers, professional development, or unrelated travel. Travel requests are submitted through OSU's CONCUR system, include a documented business purpose, and are supported by backup documentation provided with OSU's quarterly invoices to the County.

Discussion also addressed language allowing the District to retain approved funds that are not remitted to OSU. Legal Counsel and Ms. Davis discussed the County's continued control over District funds, reimbursement of OSU for actual approved expenses, and the use of retained funds for local Extension-related purposes. Commissioners emphasized the importance of ensuring that locally collected tax revenues remain under County oversight and directly benefit programs and services in Josephine County.

Following discussion, the Board agreed the agreement should be placed before the Governing Body of the Josephine County 4-H/Extension Service District for formal consideration at an upcoming Weekly Business Session. No formal action was taken.

2. CDBG Conflict of Interest Letter

Legal Counsel presented a proposed letter requesting that Business Oregon approve a conflict-of-interest exception involving Home Bridging GP, the County's subrecipient for its Community Development Block Grant Housing Rehabilitation Program. Mr. Hicks explained that Home Bridging GP's principal, Chad Hanson,

previously served on the Josephine County Budget Committee. Federal grant requirements generally continue a conflict-of-interest prohibition for one year after an individual leaves a decision-making position, creating an apparent conflict even though the County had not identified concerns regarding the quality of the work performed by Home Bridging GP.

Legal Counsel reviewed the procurement history. Home Bridging GP had previously provided housing rehabilitation services for the City of Grants Pass. When Josephine County issued a Request for Qualifications in 2024, Home Bridging GP and the County's prior contractor submitted responses. A three-member County panel evaluated the submissions, and the Board approved Home Bridging GP as the County's subrecipient in November 2024. Business Oregon subsequently approved the vendor through its own grant process. The selection occurred before the conflict created by Mr. Hanson's Budget Committee service was identified.

The proposed letter included the relevant timeline and addressed each factor Business Oregon must consider when evaluating an exception. Approval would allow the County to reconcile approximately \$14,000 remaining under the prior grant and continue pursuing the program for the next two-year grant period. Legal Counsel advised that the request was due to Business Oregon by July 17, 2026, following a three-day extension previously granted to the County.

Commissioners discussed the consequences if the exception were denied. The County would likely need to conduct another competitive selection process, identify a qualified provider, and complete the State's vendor approval process again. The Board requested that staff also begin considering a contingency plan to prevent the loss or delay of approximately \$500,000 in housing rehabilitation funding available to Josephine County residents.

Commissioner Martin stated that she had no financial interest in the matter but had previously served on the board of an organization that had also sought the work. She advised that she would abstain to avoid the appearance of a conflict

Commissioner Richardson moved to authorize Legal Counsel to submit a letter to Business Oregon requesting a Community Development Block Grant conflict-of-interest exception for Home Bridging GP. Seconded by Commissioner Smith. Upon Roll Call: Commissioner Richardson – Yes, Commissioner Martin – Abstained, Commissioner Smith – Yes. Motion carried 2-0.

3. Jail & Juvenile Justice Levy renewal - draft resolution, ballot title and explanatory statement

Legal Counsel presented a preliminary draft resolution, ballot title, and explanatory statement for renewal of the existing Adult Jail and Juvenile Detention Local Option Levy. The proposed renewal would retain the current rate of \$0.93 per \$1,000 of assessed value. Certain financial figures remained incomplete pending formal calculations from the Assessor's Office.

The proposed language would commit the County to maintaining capacity for 185 inmates in the Adult Jail. It would also state that levy revenue, combined with other funding sources, would maintain capacity for 14 youth offenders in the Juvenile Detention Center. Commissioners discussed whether the ballot language should specify the precise allocation between the two programs. Legal Counsel noted that prior levy language had not established a fixed percentage and that operational costs have changed over time.

Staff explained that approximately \$0.89 of the \$0.93 levy would now be required to operate the Adult Jail, leaving approximately \$0.04 for Juvenile Detention. Due to inflation and increased operating costs, renewal at

the same rate would no longer fully fund both programs as it had previously. Community Justice advised that approximately \$0.35 per \$1,000 would be required to fully operate the juvenile facility through a separate long-term funding mechanism.

Commissioners emphasized that the current proposal is a renewal at the existing rate and that the purpose is to maintain essential public safety capacity while the County develops a sustainable funding plan for Juvenile Justice. Discussion included the importance of clearly communicating to voters that juvenile detention reduces future adult criminal activity and remains a critical component of the County's public safety system.

By consensus, the Board directed Legal Counsel to obtain the required financial calculations from the Assessor's Office, finalize the draft documents, and return the matter to the Board for formal consideration and possible placement on the ballot. No formal action was taken.

4. SRS Election Allocation Form

Legal Counsel reviewed the County's annual election between funding under the Secure Rural Schools and Community Self-Determination Act and the traditional 1908 Act timber-receipt formula. Commissioners discussed anticipated federal timber activity, litigation that may delay future harvesting, and the relative financial stability provided by Secure Rural Schools funding. The Board concluded that the SRS election was the more prudent option under current conditions.

The Board reviewed the allowable allocations among the three SRS titles. Title I provides funding for eligible County purposes, including roads and schools. Title II supports projects on federal forest lands through the applicable resource advisory process. Title III may be used for eligible wildfire prevention, emergency services, Firewise, and related County activities. Legal Counsel confirmed that Title III was capped at seven percent and Title I could receive between 80 and 85 percent.

Commissioners expressed a preference for directing as much funding as legally permitted toward Title III because of current wildfire risks and the needs of Emergency Management and Firewise. The proposed allocation placed the maximum seven percent in Title III, eight percent in Title II, and 85 percent in Title I.

Commissioner Richardson moved to elect Secure Rural Schools funding with an allocation of 85 percent to Title I, eight percent to Title II, and seven percent to Title III. Upon roll call; Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.

5. Personnel Policy, article 4, Section 2 – At-Will Employment

Legal Counsel presented a preliminary redline revision to Article IV, Section 2 of the Josephine County Personnel Policy Manual addressing at-will employment. Mr. Hicks explained that the proposed change was intended to address procedural concerns that had recently emerged and remove unnecessary steps without changing the Board's underlying authority over at-will employees.

The proposed revision had been submitted to outside employment counsel Sean Ray for review. Mr. Ray had provided questions, and Legal Counsel was awaiting his final response. Commissioners expressed general support for the change but requested confirmation that the same or substantially similar language did not appear elsewhere in the Personnel Policy Manual or County Administrative Policies.

The Board directed Legal Counsel to complete the outside review, check all related policy provisions for consistency, and return a final recommendation for formal consideration. No formal action was taken.

6. County Administrative Policies and Procedures and County Personnel Policy Manual

Legal Counsel invited a broader discussion regarding a comprehensive review of the County Administrative Policies and Procedures and the Personnel Policy Manual. Commissioners agreed that portions of the policies may conflict, contain unclear language, or no longer reflect the County's current organizational needs.

Commissioner Richardson discussed the need to distinguish director and manager classifications more clearly. He stated that department directors and managers require leadership, technical knowledge, and organizational skills beyond those ordinarily acquired through a routine promotional progression and that County policies should reflect those expectations.

Commissioner Martin stated that the prior policy review appeared to have been completed under significant time pressure and recommended a careful, section-by-section process. She suggested using a committee or task force consisting of Commissioners and knowledgeable staff. Commissioners agreed that the County Leadership Committee and affected department heads should have an opportunity to provide input.

The Board reached consensus to continue reviewing the manuals as an ongoing project, with Legal Counsel and staff returning individual sections for discussion and approval rather than presenting the documents as one complete revision. No formal action was taken.

Chair Ron Smith called for Executive Session at 2:38 p.m. Minutes filed separately.

Additional Attendees: Wally Hicks, County Legal Counsel, Helene Lulich, Real Property Manager, and Chrissy Ewald, Daily Courier.

7. Executive Session

a. Gabbert, et al v. Josephine County; USDC 1:23-CV-01432 – ORS 192.660(2)(h)

b. Interpleader for surplus proceeds cases – ORS 192.660(2)(h)

Executive Session Adjourned at 2:56 p.m.

Legal Counsel Update Continued

8. Gabbert, et al v. Josephine County; USDC 1:23-CV-01432
9. Interpleader for surplus proceeds cases

Chair Smith announced that staff had been directed to proceed with the course of action discussed. The Board recessed for approximately five minutes and reconvened at 3:00 p.m.

b. Public Health- Animal Shelter

1. Animal Shelter Facility Upgrades

Ryan Johnson, Facilities Director and Laura Jansen, Animal Shelter Manager presented an update regarding potential improvements to the Josephine County Animal Shelter. Staff proposed beginning with Phase I of the existing master plan, which would focus on medical, clinical, intake, food storage, laundry, dishwashing, and support spaces. Establishing those functions first would prepare the facility for future kennel construction and expansion.

Ms. Jansen explained that Phase I could create an area capable of supporting in-house spay and neuter services. The ability to perform those services on site could reduce outside veterinary expenses, improve operational efficiency, and increase the number of animals served without immediately expanding staffing or the overall scope of shelter operations.

The existing plans were described as conceptual rather than construction-ready. Staff intended to revise the layout to reflect current needs, identify which elements were essential, and obtain updated cost-per-square-foot estimates. A prior grant opportunity had been sufficient to support Phase I, but the County had not secured the

award. Staff agreed to investigate whether the grant program or a similar funding opportunity may become available again.

Commissioner Richardson discussed Full Faith and Credit financing as a possible option. Such financing could spread the cost over the useful life of the improvements rather than requiring one year's taxpayers to bear the full expense. He noted that the financing would use existing County revenues and would not require a separate voter-approved tax increase. Final consideration would depend upon the project scope, updated cost estimates, and available financing terms.

Commissioner Martin requested an accompanying operational or business plan describing the public benefit, anticipated efficiencies, future maintenance costs, veterinary staffing options, and measurable outcomes. She emphasized that the Board should be able to clearly explain what the public would receive in exchange for a multimillion-dollar investment.

The Board directed Facilities and Public Health to continue developing Phase I, update the cost estimates, evaluate financing and grant opportunities, and prepare information regarding anticipated operational savings, maintenance, staffing, and service outcomes. No formal action was taken

c. Public Works

1. Purchase of 9 Vehicles- Josephine County Fleet

Rob Brandes, Public Works Director presented the scheduled purchase of nine vehicles through the Josephine County Fleet Program. Staff explained that the purchases had been included in the adopted Fiscal Year 2026-2027 budget and were generally part of the County's established replacement schedule.

The request included five replacement patrol vehicles for the Sheriff's Office, two additional vehicles for the newly approved Major Crimes detective positions, one replacement vehicle for Community Justice prevention and school-outreach services, and one transport van. Sheriff's Office representatives explained that patrol vehicles are driven extensively and include specialized equipment that affects both their useful life and resale value. Some replaced vehicles may be retained as backup units to support expansion of patrol operations, while others will be evaluated for auction.

Community Justice described its replacement vehicle as one used for school outreach, youth transportation, home visits, medical appointments, meetings, and regular travel to the Illinois Valley. The existing vehicle had developed transmission problems and could not be operated reliably under normal conditions.

Fleet staff explained that vehicles are obtained through State purchasing contracts at prices generally below retail. Departments pay mileage, operating, maintenance, and depreciation charges into the Fleet Program, allowing the County to build reserves for future replacements. Surplus vehicles are first evaluated for reassignment to other County departments before being sold at public auction.

Commissioner Richardson moved to Approve the purchase of 9 Vehicles through the Josephine County Fleet Program. Commissioner Smith seconded the motion. Upon roll call; Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.

d. Human Resources

1. Invoice for CIS in the amount of \$1,255,670.00

Natalie Eckhardt-Doupe, Interim Human Resources Director presented the County's annual CIS insurance invoice in the amount of \$1,255,670.00 for Fiscal Year 2026-2027. The renewal includes liability, property,

workers' compensation, and associated County coverage. The Board had previously authorized execution of the renewal documents on July 2, 2026; the present request was for payment of the resulting invoice.

The prior year's premium was approximately \$1,163,571, representing an increase of about seven percent. Ms. Eckhardt-Doupe explained that premiums are affected by changes in County property, vehicles, staffing, workers' compensation exposure, liability claims, and the County's recent loss history. The cost also reflects new Sheriff's Office vehicles and the potential addition of personnel approved in the current budget.

Commissioners discussed the influence of inflation and the number of lawsuits and claims defended through CIS during recent years. Staff explained that CIS uses a rolling loss history, removing an older year and adding the most recent completed year when calculating future premiums. The current renewal was based substantially on losses occurring from Fiscal Year 2021-2022 forward.

Commissioner Richardson requested a report showing the County's loss amounts for each year included in the calculation so the Board could monitor trends and better understand how claims affect insurance costs. Ms. Eckhardt-Doupe agreed to obtain the information

Commissioner Martin moved to approve the CIS Insurance Invoice in the amount of \$1,255,670.00. Commissioner Smith seconded the motion. Upon roll call; Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.

3. Board Business

a. Communications

Ryan Johnson, Facilities Director joined the Board's continued discussion regarding the County's aging public safety radio communications system. Commissioners reiterated that a complete replacement project requires development of detailed technical specifications before reliable costs can be obtained. A separate engineering consultant was reviewing the County's existing sites and coverage needs, while Day Wireless had been asked to update a prior estimate for the current mountaintop network.

Staff reported that a principal microwave link between the Justice Building and a mountaintop communications site had failed near the end of May. The failed link supports transmission to several other mountaintop sites, and its loss has created additional coverage gaps. The Sheriff's Office had characterized the condition as an officer-safety issue because deputies may need to operate in pairs in areas where radio communication is unreliable.

Day Wireless identified replacement equipment compatible with the County's existing system and potentially reusable within a future upgraded network. The proposed equipment had an estimated lead time of eight to ten weeks. Commissioners discussed whether the repair should proceed while the County continues planning a complete system replacement. The Board agreed the immediate link must be restored as soon as practicable and should not be delayed while the larger project is developed.

Commissioner Martin requested clarification regarding delivery and installation timelines, compatibility with the future system, warranties, dish alignment, and whether the quoted lead time included installation. Facilities staff agreed to conduct a joint call with Day Wireless and obtain firm scheduling information. Staff confirmed that the County controlled the necessary sites, permits and electrical service would not create significant delays, and County staff could perform the limited maintenance required after installation.

The Board also discussed the upcoming July 27 communications workshop, which would include County departments and other agencies dependent upon radio coverage. The City of Cave Junction had expressed interest in participating, and the Board discussed inviting the City of Grants Pass. Commissioners continued to support pursuit of grants and other external funding but acknowledged that the County may need to finance the complete replacement independently if outside funding is not available within a reasonable timeframe.

Commissioner Martin moved to approve up to \$85,837.29 from the Building Reserve Fund for Facilities to proceed with the Day Wireless microwave-link upgrade, subject to satisfactory clarification of equipment delivery and installation timeframes. Commissioner Smith seconded the motion. Upon Roll Call: Commissioner Richardson – Yes; Commissioner Martin – Yes; Commissioner Smith – Yes. Motion carried 3-0.

b. 4H Extension Reserve

The Board discussed the District's building reserve fund, which expired on June 30, 2026, after its most recent ten-year authorization period. Commissioner Richardson stated that the fund had been in existence for approximately 20 years and questioned whether it remained necessary now that the District's current facility expenses and furnishings had been included in the adopted annual budget.

Discussion included whether the remaining balance must continue to be used exclusively for 4-H/Extension purposes, whether the reserve should be reauthorized for another ten years, and what legal process applies if the Board allows the fund to expire. Legal Counsel had begun researching the statutory requirements but was not prepared to provide a final recommendation.

The Board agreed to table the matter and directed Legal Counsel to return with an explanation of the available legal options and permissible uses of the remaining balance. No formal action was taken.

3. OTHER

None heard

4. ADDITIONAL SUBJECT MATTERS FROM COMMISSIONERS/ANNOUNCEMENTS:

None heard

The meeting adjourned at 4:06 p.m.